mathematics of topology, they could not compete with the British. They didn't even try; their attention was riveted elsewhere.

Lev Davidovich Landau, who was largely responsible for the strength of Soviet theoretical physics in the 1930s through 1960s, was also a source of Soviet resistance to topology: Landau had transfused theoretical physics from Western Europe to the U.S.S.R. in the 1930s (Chapter 5). As one tool in that transfusion, he had created a set of examinations on theoretical physics, called the "Theoretical Minimum", which he required be passed as an entree into his own research group. Anyone, regardless of educational background, could walk in off the street and take these examinations, but few could pass them. In the twenty-nine years of the Theoretical Minimum (1933–62) only forty-three passed, but a remarkable portion of those forty-three went on to make great physics discoveries.



Evgeny Michailovich Lifshitz *(left)* and Lev Davidovich Landau *(right)* in Landau's room in his flat at the Institute for Physical Problems, No. 2 Vorobyevskoye Shosse, Moscow, in 1954.
[Courtesy Lifshitz's wife, Zinaida Ivanovna Lifshitz.]